

Oregon Policy Project (OPP) Handbook

Version 1.0 – July 2026

Mission Statement

The Oregon Policy Project (OPP) is dedicated to improving Oregon state government through rigorous, nonpartisan, evidence-based research and legislative analysis.

Research Philosophy

Understand Oregon government before attempting to change it. Research precedes recommendations. Evidence precedes legislation. Patterns precede conclusions.

Project Scope

Oregon state government only. Primary sources: Secretary of State performance audits, statutes, administrative rules, legislative materials, agency reports, peer-reviewed research, and limited comparative research.

Research Pipeline

Question → Collect Evidence → Verify Evidence → Code Evidence → Identify Patterns → Test Alternative Explanations → Develop Policy Options → Evaluate Tradeoffs → Recommend Action → Draft Legislation (if warranted).

Programs

Government Performance; Natural Resources; Infrastructure; Democratic Institutions.

Project Alpha (OPAC)

Create a complete research-grade database of Oregon Secretary of State Performance Audits (2010–2026).

Database Structure

Current tables: agencies, audits, findings, recommendations, root_causes, recommendation_root_causes, sources. Planned additions: themes, government_functions, solution_types, implementation_status_history, coders, audit_series.

Root Cause Taxonomy

RC01 Governance; RC02 Strategic Planning; RC03 Performance Management; RC04 Internal Controls; RC05 Procurement & Contract Management; RC06 Information Technology; RC07 Workforce Capacity; RC08 Financial Management; RC09 Compliance; RC10 Interagency Coordination; RC11 Risk Management; RC12 Public Transparency.

Coding Principles

Recommendations are the primary unit of analysis. Code what the audit says. Every coding decision must cite evidence.

Research Rules

CR-001 PDF verification required. CR-002 Code audit text faithfully. CR-003 Conclusions must be reproducible.

Quality Assurance

Data accuracy, coding consistency, analytical review.

Evidence Completeness Scale

0 Metadata only; 1 PDF verified; 2 Findings extracted; 3 Recommendations extracted; 4 Fully coded; 5 QA verified.

Data Decisions

Oregon-only scope; performance audits only; official metadata sources; recommendations as unit of analysis; legislation only after evidence shows recurring systemic problems.

Version Roadmap

1.x Corpus; 2.x Coding; 3.x Analysis; 4.x Publication.

Long-Term Vision

Build a permanent, transparent, reproducible research resource focused on improving Oregon government.